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Indigenous dialogic teaching: Orality in a Tibetan school in China

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ABSTRACT

This article describes the use of dialogic teaching in a rural Tibetan school in China. Using ethnographic data from a school that serves socially disadvantaged Tibetan youth, we demonstrate that dialogic teaching is a powerful pedagogy even in a resource-deprived learning environment. We describe how oral commentary, interpretive discussions, and debate form the core of effective school practices. Inspired by traditional monastic training, schoolteachers have transformed the century-long indigenous oral practices into a culturally-appropriate form of pedagogy, infusing it into modern academic subjects. This article aims to enrich the growing literature on dialogic teaching by presenting a case outside Anglo-American societies. We examine an indigenous form of dialogic teaching by considering Alexander (2017, 2020)'s framework. Our analysis shows that while the specific pedagogy is developed indigenously, it is compatible with the dialogic philosophy. The findings suggest that the dialogic approach is a general pedagogy rooted in distinctive human societies. However, indigenous development also limits the school practices to a small repertoire.

1. Introduction

> The primary exchange, which constitutes the basis of all others, is that of words.
> – Claude Hagège, *The Dialogic Species*. 1985/1990, p. viii.

Using language as a tool for teaching and learning is one of the most well-established ideas in the educational sciences. Contemporary research often traces its roots to philosophers such as Gadamer, Wittgenstein, Vygotsky, Bruner, or Bakhtin (e.g. Alexander, 2020; Haroutunian-Gordon, 2009; Sfard, 2008). Several studies and practical programs have been inspired by related ideas (Kim & Wilkinson, 2019). Outside of the scientific discourse, there are diverse pedagogical traditions that champion cognate ideas. These practices, often homespun or indigenous, have yet to be examined by Anglophone researchers. They have different philosophical bearings and are implemented to invoke different conditions. This paper provides one such case to the current discussion of dialogic teaching.[1] We aim to examine an indigenous form of dialogic teaching by considering the dialogic teaching framework (Alexander, 2017, 2020). We show how teaching in a rural Tibetan-serving school is compatible with the principles of a modern framework. We

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[1] Here, we would like to distinguish the definitions of several significant terms used in this paper. "Dialogic teaching" refers to a specific pedagogical approach, representing an abstract concept. "Dialogic practices" encompass a wider range of teaching and learning activities that embody dialogic elements, representing the practical/tangible implementation of such approaches. "Oral practices" refer to teaching practices described independently of the theoretical framework of dialogic teaching.

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also intend to use this case as a heuristic to broaden the current discourse on promoting students' thinking, learning, and problem-solving.

This study presents the following findings and contributions. First, our case highlights the centrality of dialogic teaching as a general pedagogy in the school setting. We illustrate its versatility and elasticity. Dialogic teaching can be extended to a wide range of students, incorporated into many subjects, and used in several different situations. Second, we agree with Alexander (2001) that teaching is located within the culture. A dialogic approach to teaching is an attractor that leads learners toward culturally-relevant topics. This feature is beneficial for indigenous learners who were disenchanted by prescribed curricula.

Third, the improvisational nature of teaching is vividly embodied in oral forms. While orality and written texts are essential sources for school learning, textbook is privileged and authoritative in many education systems, including China's. Following prescribed texts, instruction typically falls into rigidity and routine. However, the dialogic approach constantly creates new social spaces through debate, comment, questioning, and reflection because the interlocution motivates teachers and students with authentic problems rather than offering each other fixed answers. This is when students enlarge their "general capacity to 'tool themselves' to fit the world" (Martin, 2011, p. 263) via habitual reasoning. The practice-in-"speaking" aspect reflects our understanding of generating expert knowledge in a situated learning environment (Daipha, 2015, p. 10–13).

Finally, the research community can benefit from the multitudes of dialogic traditions. Using dialogic methods is perhaps a defining characteristic of our species ever since we created language (Hagège, 1990, chapter 3). The dialogic tradition appeared in many different cultures based on a distinctive philosophy of learning (Fuller, 2001; Taluah, 2015). Since these traditions had varying degrees of temporal lineages, examining them in detail forces us to be more sensitive to the particularities of the teaching and learning process. We are constantly reminded to drop our preconceptions of learning by provincializing the present (Abbott, 2016, p. 281, 290). However, a purely particular approach to teaching and learning is equally problematic as it denies other valid experiences. As such, we view our project as a translation "in making the systemic leap from one social standpoint to another" (Celarent, 2017, p. 104–105).[2] This study is a valid heuristic case that opens the door to mutual reflection between widely accepted models of dialogic teaching and indigenous practices of dialogic teaching.

Our case is part of a larger project on the schooling of Tibetan youth in contemporary China. In many ethnic minority communities, orality is among the most relied upon pedagogical approaches (Wu, 2017). Yet many state-sponsored schools lean toward academic production, where a more instruction-heavy approach has been adopted (Tong & Zhou, 2021). For instance, observers reported that one-way oral instruction is the most common form of pedagogy, while teachers do not like students to talk back. The argument is a sign of disruption and contention. Practitioners equate diligence to silent hardworking (Wu, 2016).

This lecture-centric form of pedagogy runs the danger of disengaging students. This is particularly crucial regarding minority students whose first language is not the national standard language, who lack the academic background to accumulate knowledge, and who have suffered disengagement as a result. As such, field research and survey responses have reported degrees of disenchantment in classrooms (Wu, 2012). The official school system in the Tibetan region has been classified into two models: bilingual education and monolingual Chinese education (Wang, 2022). Yet, in such vast and remote areas, they are not all-encompassing. During our fieldwork in the northwestern province of Qinghai, we encountered a school seemingly falling through the cracks of either stream. This secondary school, pseudo-named "Raja," took in youth who were dropouts or grade repeaters by ordinary standards. The students either did not receive any schooling or needed to be better adjusted to the formal school system. At the age of fourteen, after finishing state compulsory education, the students who are not academically competent enough usually return to their family grazing land or enter the labor market.

Raja provided these students with continued learning opportunities for a small fee. The school's curriculum combines the state version with vocational skills. Kids learn both national courses and traditional Tibetan knowledge. In addition to regular fourteen-year-olds, the school also takes in illiterate young adults. Instead of focusing on drilling and cramming, the schoolteachers infuse forms of orality familiar to the students in their daily practices. Traditionally, orality plays a significant role in Tibetan scholastic culture. The main activity of Tibetan scholasticism involves memorization, oral commentary, and dialectical debate (Dreyfus, 2003). Traditional monastic education has mostly been replaced by school education in China, but local residents maintain a strong cultural tradition. They grow up chanting scripts, speaking prayers, and singing songs.

In the next section, we introduce the context of the Raja school. Next, we situate our paper in the century-long Tibetan philosophy of teaching and learning with orality. We describe how dialogic teaching is interpreted in modern academia. We then present our cases with a description and analysis of several activities inside the school. We map it back to the modern dialogic teaching framework. We further examine whether an indigenous form of dialogic teaching could make sense in a modern framework. Our discussion highlights the school's benefits and limitations.

2. Ethnographic context and methodology

This research is situated in Qinghai province's Three-River Headwater (TRH henceforward) region in Northwest China. Qinghai is a multi-ethnic province populated by diverse ethnic groups. The TRH region is the main settlement of Tibetans in Qinghai. It is located in the hinterland of the Qinghai-Tibet Plateau of high altitude, low oxygen levels, harsh climate, and poor living conditions. Today, more than 90 % of the existing population of the TRH region is Tibetan, and most of them are herders.

[2] A remarkable collection of such cases is included in Celarent (2017). Park (2017) offered a view from Asia.

This study is based on data from a broader project investigating the schooling and disenchantment of Tibetan youth in contemporary China.[3] The empirical data presented in this study is derived from 12 months of ethnographic fieldwork conducted between 2019 and 2021 in Qinghai. Our research site is a Tibetan-serving school, the Raja vocational secondary school (*pseudonym*). Jigme, a Tibetan Buddhist monk in a county in the TRH region, founded it in 1994. The Raja school is a private school for school-aged Tibetan children who have never attended school, for those who have dropped out of public primary or secondary school, and for students who have exceeded the age limit of compulsory education. As such, these students have yet to develop any real academic foundation before entering school. Initially, Raja enrolled many unschooled Tibetan children. The Chinese state has recently required that school-aged children (under fourteen) receive compulsory education. Therefore, Raja had to transform itself into a vocational school and could only recruit illiterate adults and students over fourteen.

Currently, Raja houses about 1500 students, all of whom are Tibetan males, most of whom are from low-income nomadic families. Raja also recruits Tibetan monks from various monasteries. As Raja was initially a welfare school for those from poor families, the headmaster Jigme insisted that no tuition or miscellaneous fees would be charged. Orphans, disabled children, and poverty-stricken children can also obtain subsidies. Raja is also a well-staffed school. Many teachers are eminent Tibetan monks, famous experts or scholars in Buddhology, and teaching professionals with master's and doctoral degrees.

The Raja school combines the basic department (grades 7 to 9) with the vocational department (grades 10 to 12), with a total instructional duration of six years. Students in the basic department typically study the national textbooks for compulsory education, such as Chinese, mathematics, English, basic Tibetan, etc. The vocational department primarily focuses on vocational skills training and improving the employment level of the students. It offers many vocational training courses such as Tibetan language teaching, Tibetan medicine, computing, Thangka painting (Tibetan Buddhist scroll painting), English language teaching, Tibetan video production, Tibetan architecture, etc. There are also short-term technical training courses such as carving, ware manufacturing, felt weaving, electrical maintenance, cheese processing technology, driver training, etc. Both departments offer classes on traditional Tibetan culture. These courses are based on the Five Sciences,[4] the five kinds of knowledge in ancient Indian Buddhism.

During this study's fieldwork, we combined participant observation with semi-structured interviews. We obtained informed consent from all participants before conducting any research activities. The observations include classroom observation, students living at the school, teacher-student daily interactions, and school activities. Video-ethnography is frequently used to collect observational data. It enables the detailed examination of dialogic teaching, social behaviors, communication patterns, nonverbal cues, and contextual factors that may not be adequately captured through traditional ethnographic methods alone. The recorded video footage is typically analyzed alongside field notes, transcriptions, and other qualitative data.

Furthermore, we conducted open-ended interviews with teachers, students, school principals, staff, and parents/guardians. In Raja, 22 lower-secondary students, 28 upper-secondary students, 16 teachers (including eight monk teachers), two principals, six school staff, and 22 parents/guardians were interviewed. Focus group discussions were also conducted with students (each group had four to six individuals) to gain an in-depth understanding of their school life and social interaction issues. All interviews were conducted in the school field during participants' leisure time. Questions were mainly asked about their personal background, their experiences at Raja, their views of teaching and learning, their expectations for the future, etc. The interviews were conducted in both Mandarin and Tibetan. With the assistance of our Tibetan translator, each interview took about 40–60 min. Additionally, informal conversations were conducted with these participants, the graduates, and some villagers in the TRH region.

All text-based materials were organized by the qualitative data analysis software NVivo 12 for coding, thereby identifying themes and the relationship between categories (Saldaña, 2016). We followed the procedures of "flexible coding" proposed by Deterding and Waters (2018) as we agree with them that this analytic method can better increase transparency, reliability, and validity. The analysis also draws on oral history, archives, field notes, policy documents, and institutional records.

3. Tibetan philosophy of teaching and learning with orality

Over the long history of Buddhist scholasticism and epistemology, it is believed that sentient beings suffer continuously in the prison of cycle existence (Tibetan: *'khor ba;* Sanskrit: *saṃsāra*) due to their ignorance (Tibetan: *ma rig pa;* Sanskrit: *avidya*) (Duckworth, 2019, p. 24). Buddhist practitioners are directed toward the following goal: eliminating ignorance, obtaining real wisdom, and achieving nirvana (Siderits, 2016; Thurman, 1991). Tibetan scholasticism holds that one can achieve the ultimate truth and be freed by defeating misconceptions, establishing defensible views, and seeing the nature of things. Thus, the central purpose of Tibetan monastic education is to distinguish others' positions, establish one's own argumentation, and respond to criticism (Perdue, 1992).

Oral practice is part of this learning effort because, in Tibetan scholastic culture, language skills are deemed one of the essential

[3] The broader research aims to explore the factors that contribute to the disengagement/disenchantment of Tibetan students from their academic pursuits in modern schooling. However, during the research journey, Raja emerged as a unique case where disenchantment was notably absent. Subsequently, we discovered that the implementation of indigenous pedagogies at Raja, particularly dialogic teaching, has effectively diminished the disenchantment experienced by students. Therefore, we embarked several studies to investigate how the indigenous pedagogies shape the experiences of disenchanted Tibetan youth. This study is one of the products of our extensive research conducted at Raja.

[4] The Five Sciences (Tibetan: *rigné chenpo nga*; Sanskrit: *pañcavidyā*; Chinese: 五明学) is the general normative model of learning in Tibetan monasteries (Dreyfus, 2003; Naga, 2006). It consists of five major and five minor branches of learning. The five major branches of learning are Buddhology, logic and epistemology, grammar, arts and crafts, and medicine. The five minor ones are poetics, metrics, lexicography, drama, and astrology.

qualifications of a great master (Naga, 2006). Tibetan scholasticism emphasizes the interpretation of great texts, within the confines of its authority, for traditional needs to be constantly interpreted and inherited (Dreyfus, 2003). Various forms of orality constitute the core educative method and provide Tibetan monasteries with their focus of activity (Klein, 2003). Generally, Tibetan scholasticism is characterized by three types of oral practice: memorization, oral commentary, and dialectical debate (Dreyfus, 2003).[5]

Memorization is the first step to beginning a career as a Tibetan Buddhist monk in any monastery. Tibetan monastic education often starts with basic literature, reciting religious texts, and chanting scriptures. Monks typically have a large number of textual materials to memorize before they are allowed to participate in more sophisticated oral practices. Instead of silent reading, memorization is practiced loudly by monks to be "held in mind." The repetitive recitation highlights the rhythm of vocalized texts and the sound itself. In the Tibetan tradition, reading aloud is believed to bear physical and mental effects that can mute or transform one's "inner chatter," which interferes with concentration (Klein, 1994). Therefore, this first step of oral practice is concerned with producing mental concentration.

The second central practice of monastic education is interpreting constitutive texts using teachers' oral commentary (Dreyfus, 2003). Tibetan scholasticism relies on textual materials as a basis for lectures and discussions. However, religious texts (usually scriptures) are understood via communal effort. Without the commentary of a qualified teacher, it is challenging to amplify the meaning of the text in terms of logic and epistemology. Therefore, the teacher's commentary is a crucial element of learning through which the knowledge is transmitted, interpreted, expanded, criticized, and enshrined (Klein, 1994). Such oral philosophy interprets, questions, and extends the text through the teacher's reflections or the discussions between the teacher and the students, thus enabling students to understand the texts deeply.

Third, the passive reception of oral commentary is complemented by another principal means of learning: debate. Through this chief academic training activity, monks are expected to debate the meaning of the text to unravel its intent. Unlike modern debates, monastic debate aims to crystalize different views rather than to defeat or embarrass the opponent (Perdue, 1992). Great emphasis is placed on knowledge, logical/critical thinking, interpretive abilities, and esoteric understandings to be gained through debate. While oral commentary transmits knowledge from teacher to student, debate consolidates learning among students. It is a highly social and interactive practice in which monks seek to jointly deepen their understanding of memorized materials using constant questioning (van Vugt et al., 2019). Debate itself involves a great deal of memorization and commentary of texts. Typically, the knowledge gained from oral incantation and commentary is intended for the practice of debate. Only after one memorizes the text and receives the interpretation from teachers can they debate the topic with others. Thus, these oral processes often intertwine with each other.

Tibetan Buddhist pedagogy largely relies on these oral practices: the rhythmic recitation of textual materials, interpreting texts through commentary, and exploring their meaning through dialectical debate. As Ong (1982) argues, Tibetan monastic culture is essentially an oral culture, and textual learning is achievable through orality. Engaging in the texts means literary understanding and incorporating such oral performance. By examining oral traditions in monasteries, we show how Tibetan education functions with orality. The following section describes how orality is interpreted in modern academia. We then present this article's analytical framework.

4. Dialogic teaching approach in Anglo-American societies

The deliberative use of language as a tool in teaching and learning is one of the most well-established ideas in the educational sciences. The importance of dialogue in learning came to the forefront in 1966 at an Anglo-American conference on teaching English (Dixon, 1967). Since then, dialogic teaching has become the focus of much research and variously interpreted and tested by Anglophone researchers (Kim & Wilkinson, 2019). The modern iterations of the dialogic tradition vary; more recent versions include Burbules' dialogical teaching (Burbules, 1993), Resnick's accountable talk (Resnick, 1999), Wegerif's dialogic space (Wegerif, 2013), and Matusov's dialogic pedagogy (Matusov, 2009), to name a few.[6]

Among the diverse models of dialogic teaching, Robin Alexander (2017, 2020)'s framework is arguably one of the most widely circulated and immensely influential models.[7] Alexander (2020, p. 128) defined dialogic teaching as a pedagogical approach that capitalizes on the power of talk to stimulate and extend students' thinking, learning, knowing, and understanding while enabling them to discuss, reason, and argue. It is often invoked when describing various pedagogies of classroom talk (Resnick et al., 2015). He developed the concept of dialogic teaching and summarized a set of principles, repertoires, and indicators that could bring conceptual clarity to the construct of the dialogic teaching approach. In a recent book, Alexander (2020) identified six *principles* of dialogic teaching to serve as criteria for judging what kind of talk can accurately be called 'dialogic.' He listed that dialogic teaching is (see Table 1):

[5] According to Wegerif (2008), the difference between 'dialogic' and 'dialectic' lies in the former assumes that meaning is created through the interaction of different voices and perspectives, while the latter assumes that meaning is created through the resolution of contradictions.

[6] "Dialogic teaching" is a loose concept that lacks a fixed definition and instead encompasses a wide range of ideas, allowing for diverse interpretations among researchers (Calcagni & Lago, 2018; Kim & Wilkinson, 2019). We hesitate to categorize Raja's practices as definitively "dialogic". Because the concept of "dialogic teaching" is too broad and general, making it challenging to precisely measure how closely Raja's practices align with a specific interpretation of dialogic teaching. Here, we would like to clarify that this study primarily focused on "translation". Our goal is to translate these indigenous practices to the external world rather than to measure whether Raja's practices can be characterized as "dialogic".

[7] Alexander's book on this topic has gone through five editions and twenty-two prints from 2014 to 2019. It is an immensely popular work among practitioners and researchers.

Alexander noted that the first three principles characterize the collaborative culture where dialogue is most likely to prosper. In contrast, the last three address the content and trajectory of the talk (Alexander, 2020, p. 131). Therefore, we follow Alexander's conceptualization of dialogic teaching. As such, we further examine whether an indigenous form of dialogic teaching could make sense in a modern framework. Specifically, we investigate whether the century-long Tibetan oral practices are compatible with or differ from the principles that emerged from Anglo-American discourse.

The dialogic tradition has appeared in many different cultures based on distinctive learning philosophies (Fuller, 2001; Taluah, 2015). Our study offers a case to understand the general structure of one indigenous tradition. In the next section, we describe how educators in Raja applied indigenous oral practices to daily teaching activities and how orality forms the core of school practices.

5. Dialogic practices in Raja

During our field research, Raja adhered to the following daily routine: students got up at 6:00, followed by their morning reading classes from 6:30 to 7:30. From 8:10 to 17:50, students attended the rest of their courses (five classes a day, 1 h each). Teachers mainly relied on textual materials in class as a basis for commentary or discussions. During the school day, students were also required to participate in the twice-daily, 30-minute-long debate session from 11:40 to 12:10 and from 18:00 to 18:30. After dinner, the recitation session occurred from 19:00 to 20:00, and students would go to the playground and recite aloud what they had learned that day. Then, students engaged in a self-study session from 20:30 to 22:30.

The pedagogical approaches adopted in Raja are similar to what we typically find in a Tibetan Buddhist monastery. Oral recitation, commentary, interpretive discussion, and debate form the core of school practices. We observed that schoolteachers in Raja emphasize dialogic teaching more than in other Tibetan schools (Tong & Zhou, 2021). Instead of focusing on drilling and cramming, the schoolteachers infused forms of orality familiar to the students in their daily practices. We analyzed such dialogic teaching in two categories, as indicated below.

5.1. Learning through commentary and discussion

In typical patterns of classroom discourse described by Greeno et al. (1996), one-way oral instruction is the most common form of pedagogy. Traditional didactic instruction still dominates in many schools in China, mainly rural/ethnic schools (Wu, 2018). Raja is different in this regard. The teachers we observed would hold conversations in their classes rather than lecture the students. Consequently, our observations illustrate that learners were more actively engaged in situations like these. The most pronounced cases occurred during Tibetan/Chinese literature class (see Fig. 1).

Similar to the tradition of oral commentary in monasteries, Raja teachers relied on textual materials as a basis for teaching. A typical class starts when the teachers offer "discussable" texts for the students to interpret and reflect upon. After the initial readout by the students, the teacher would initiate a round of discussion. The following is an example of dialogic teaching in a Tibetan literature class. One day, Lobsang, a Tibetan literature teacher, assigned the students to read a copy of *Drimed Kuenden* (an ancient folktale named after a prince). The story revolves around Drimed Kuenden's selfless dedication to his country and people. Here is an excerpt from "Commentary 01" after the student's first read.[8]

Lobsang (teacher): Why does Drimed Kuenden decide to give his eyes to the elders?

Lhak: Because he wants the elders to see the light again. He is a selfless and kind person.

Penpa: He cannot stand the suffering of others. Even if he is unjustly blamed by his people, he still helps others generously.

(Some other students also expressed the same views as above. Omitted here.)

Lobsang: You all agreed that he did it because of his own personality. He is a kind, selfless, warm-hearted person. Is that right?

Students: (together) Yes!

Lobsang: Now, think about it. If you were him, would you do that? Will you give your eyes, treasures, and even your children and wife to others?

Wangdrak: I think I will give away everything I have. Because this old story aims to teach us to contribute selflessly to others. Dedication is also a virtue advocated by Buddhism, my teachers, and my parents since I was a child. If I can save many people only by sacrificing myself, I think it is worth doing.

Lobsang: But you also need to sacrifice your family. Are you willing to do so?

Wangdrak: Um, if I can really save many people, I will. Because I believe in the theory of "Cause and Effect (Sanskrit: hetu-phala; Chinese: 因果论)" in Buddhism, I don't want to suffer from reincarnation. If I haven't done good things in my life, how can I achieve good results in my next life?

Lobsang: I'm glad you deeply understand "Cause and Effect" and have a noble morality. Anybody else?

Tse: It seems that the action of Drimed Kuenden is very contradictory. While he has loving-kindness, he is also a selfish person. He sent his wife and children to others without considering their feelings. He is selfless to his people but selfish to his family.

Lobsang: That is a very interesting comment. Anybody else?

(Some other students also expressed the same views as Tse. Omitted here.)

Sonam: I agreed with Tse and disagreed with Wangdrak. It seems that you sacrifice yourself just because you want to benefit yourself from reincarnation and get a good fate in your next life. Isn't this another kind of selfishness? I think you have to figure out what your sacrifice is really for if you are Drimed Kuenden.

Lobsang: Your opinion makes sense. Many of you disagree with the prince's action of sacrificing the minority for the prosperity of the majority. This is an interesting topic that deserves our attention. Then, are you willing to sacrifice yourself?

(*continued on next page*)

[8] Due to space limitations, we cannot enclose the full transcripts of the commentaries and debates in the article. We have compiled a comprehensive addendum with all the transcriptions. It can be accessed online via: https://github.com/anonymince/Indigenous_Dialogic_Teaching_Appendix/blob/main/Supplemental%20Material.pdf. Alternatively, see Appendix A for details.

Table 1
Alexander's six principles of dialogic teaching (compiled by the authors).

- Collective: the classroom is a site of joint learning and inquiry; students and teachers address learning tasks together.
- Supportive: students feel able to express ideas freely, without fear of embarrassment over 'wrong' answers; they help each other reach common understandings.
- Reciprocal: teachers and students listen to each other, share ideas, ask questions, and consider alternative viewpoints.
- Deliberative: participants discuss and seek to resolve different points of view; they present and evaluate arguments and work toward reasoned positions and outcomes.
- Cumulative: teachers and students build on their own and each other's contributions and chain them into coherent lines of thinking and understanding.
- Purposeful: teachers plan and facilitate dialogic teaching with specific learning goals in view.

Fig. 1. Dialogic teaching in Tibetan literature class.

(*continued*)

Sonam: I am not sure. I dare not say I will become such a kind and selfless person. But if the minister hurts my family, then I will make a desperate attempt to save my family without considering my own life.
Lobsang: Thanks for your honesty. It seems that everyone has different views on the meaning of dedication and selflessness…

The Drimed Kuendan story is a mainstay in Tibetan literature. In other Tibetan schools we visited, many teachers would teach such stories with a didactic approach by first reading the story (or its main paragraphs) and encouraging students to draw a predefined conclusion. Particularly in Tibetan/Chinese literature classes in other schools, we often witnessed students reciting the lines of the text without understanding the character's motives, conflicts, and struggles.

However, Raja's teachers approached the topic differently. For example, Lobsang required students to interpret the text after the first read. Then, the teacher tasked students to imagine themselves as character and to empathize with Drimed Kuendan. When the opinions converged, the teacher deliberately presented another voice for discussion. The subsequent discussion followed a similar structure: the teacher asked the students to put themselves in the character's shoes to seek consensus or dissent.

As one spoke, the teacher and peers could question the speaker's assumptions and beliefs. The class never broke down to a one-on-one teacher querying the student while the rest sat back and listened. Collective action always involved multiple students at the same time. The teacher sometimes modified the question or gave way to another question as the conversation progressed. Interpretations evolved as new ideas about the text entered the conversation. The teacher sought to embrace and resolve different viewpoints, and deliberative action ran through the conversation. Each student's ideas were summarized and reiterated by the teacher but never pushed for a fixed interpretation. In our view, the teacher and students worked together to create a mutually-supportive and reciprocal atmosphere. In such a class, ideas can flow freely (though the teacher initiates the discussion), and students can consider alternative views with their own reasoning.

The commentary was always attached to the student experience. This "learning from experiences" method was also common in

other classes in Raja. The teacher could lead learners toward a deeper understanding of the text by guiding students to reflect upon their personal past. Another excerpt from "Commentary 01" shows Ngak's reflection.

Lobsang: That sounds pathetic. Why would you do that?

Ngak: Um…When I was a little kid, my father sacrificed silently for our family. He is the only source of income in our family. He worked hard from dawn to dusk all year round to earn money. He taught me what love really is. I think love is more about dedication. We can't only think for ourselves. More often, you just need more patience and endurance.

Lobsang: So it seems that your decision depends on your personal experience. Is that right?

Ngak: Yes…

The conversation became a medium through which students connected past experiences with the text. The success of the class was anchored in this process of students learning to attach new meaning to their lives. In the case above, a student may begin to rethink the meaning of selflessness and dedication through the study of *Drimed Kuenden*. Such a conversation is similar to the pedagogical method of interpretive discussion described by Haroutunian-Gordon (1998). Interpretive discussion aims to enable learners to delve deeply into texts and better understand their meaning through the teacher's commentary and mutual discussions. Haroutunian-Gordon (1991, p. 53) noted that an excellent interpretive discussion should meet at least three criteria: engaging interests, connecting personal experience with the text, and generating new ideas about the topic. The discussions in Raja's many classes achieved these goals.

However, we found that discussions in Raja were not always designed with specific learning goals. Conversations that incorporated personal experiences quickly became off-topic chatter. Nonetheless, when we posed the question, many teachers defended this approach because they believe the oral practice is aimed at cultivating students' dialectical thinking ability. Influenced by Tibetan monastic culture, the significance of talk is to defeat misconceptions, establish defensible views, and discover the nature of things (Perdue, 1992). Through free discussion, the Raja teachers expected students to learn more about the way of thinking rather than sticking too precisely to specific knowledge points. They focused more on the learning process rather than the content.

Principal Jigme told us, "we not only deliver booklore to students. More importantly, we want to teach them a methodology for lifelong learning. we want to cultivate students' intelligence in questioning, reasoning, and argumentation." Our discussion with the teachers indicates that many were unaware of the modern, purposeful principle (Alexander, 2020), where teachers design and promote dialogic teaching with specific learning goals.

There are exceptions to our findings. In a memorable film study class, Ms. Cui played a documentary filmed by a local director. The documentary focuses on environmental deterioration in Tibetan areas and the impact of the decline of nomadic culture. Afterward, Ms. Cui initiated a discussion on the same topic concentrating on the local community. In addition to creating a collaborative, supportive, and reciprocal atmosphere in class, we observed purposeful directions by the teacher. A sequence of unfolding questions guided students to put forward new ideas and summarize things they have learned (see an excerpt from "Commentary 02").

Ms. Cui (teacher): … I guess you all understand what this documentary is trying to deliver. Let me make a summary…

…

Ms. Cui (teacher): … (Ms. Cui summarized different opinions from students. Omitted here.) … I want to ask you guys: how should we understand the relationship between the environment and ourselves? This is also the most important question I hope you can think about…

…

Ms. Cui (teacher): Thank you all for sharing your experiences. From the perspective of Tibetan culture, life and environment depend on each other. Then, let's summarize what we have talked about today. What enlightenment or contribution can Tibetan nomadic culture bring to the global ecological crisis?

Compared to Mr. Lobsang's class, Ms. Cui set specific learning goals for the discussion. The teacher intentionally guided students to reconsider the relationship between humans and nature, the concept of environmental protection, and the essence of nomadic life from the perspective of Tibetans. In the after-class discussion, Ms. Cui claimed that the conversation aims to connect the environmental crisis with philosophical and critical thinking in Tibetan Buddhism. Since many students grew up immersed in the Buddhist tradition, by providing students with meaningful and culture-related texts, she hopes that students' understanding of traditional culture and local theories can be reshaped through the discussion. After the discussion, she assigned the students to produce a short video conveying an eco-friendly message from a Tibetan perspective. Ms. Cui planned and facilitated the whole teaching process with clear goals.

In general, the indigenous form of dialogic teaching is broadly compatible with the dialogic philosophy in Anglo-American societies. Raja teachers tended to build an environment of active knowledge-making for learners, while their questions served as catalysts. They created a collaborative learning environment where students could listen to each other, articulate their ideas freely, and talk openly. We found that Raja teachers avoided giving verbal judgments of right or wrong regarding students' ideas during discussions. Deliberative teaching enabled all participants to work together to resolve problems and help each other to reach a reasoned consensus. We also found that much of the dialogue in Raja was not structured with specific learning goals. Despite many teachers' attempts to keep the conversation from diverging into irrelevancy, few could maintain the particular learning goals throughout the entire class, with a few exceptions.

Influenced by Tibetan monastic culture, the teacher's commentary rarely guided the direction of the discussion purposefully. The free-wheeling nature of the conversations may be one reason we seldom found that students could accumulate knowledge systematically via discussion in Raja. Without purposeful lesson planning, many teachers may not be able to chain their ideas into coherent lines of thinking and understanding. In this sense, conversation-based teaching in Raja meets Alexander's collective, supportive, reciprocal, and deliberative principles but fails to, or rarely achieves, cumulative and purposeful results.

5.2. Learning through debate

The most special segment of the day in Raja was the debate sessions. Debate-based pedagogy, a unique dialogic method, originates from the tradition of monastic debate in Tibetan Buddhism. Monastic debate is rooted in "Yin-Ming (Sanskrit: *hetuvidyā*; Chinese: 因明学)," an ancient Buddhist lore of logical reasoning and epistemology. Yin-Ming literally means "elucidation of the cause/reason (Yin 因) (Assandri, 2014) and gain wisdom (Ming 明)." It is a crucial component of the philosophy training of Tibetan monks. In monasteries, the Yin-Ming debate is an everyday, all-day-long affair. Only when monks fully understand Yin-Ming logic can they participate in the debate.

Unlike the common debate we usually understand, the pith of the Yin-Ming debate is not to defeat the opponent but to reach a philosophical consensus. It involves continually placing the participants' thinking at risk by challenging each other frequently with questions like "What is the consequence of that?" "Is this not the consequence?" "What consequences will it lead to?" (Liberman, 1992). The debaters are like consequence-seekers, trying to elicit ideas according to the consequences of collaborative reasoning.

The principal, Jigme, initially launched the application of the Yin-Ming style of debate in the Raja school. As a Tibetan Buddhist monk who obtained the Geshe (Sanskrit: *kalyāṇamitra;* Chinese: 格西) degree (the terminal degree of monastic education), Jigme received decades of rigorous debate-based philosophical monastic education. He believes that debate-based pedagogy is conducive to cultivating students' intelligence, logical/critical thinking, expression ability, creativity, etc. To enable students to learn through debate, the school offers a one-year introductory course on Yin-Ming for first-year students in grade 7 to teach them how to think, ask questions and answer questions in the way of Yin-Ming. Students can participate in debate practice, starting in grade 8, after learning the entire set of Yin-Ming debating methods.

Debate sessions are typically held on the playground or in the open space of the schoolyard. During the sessions we observed, students all gathered and started debating loudly. The debate includes two levels: primary (for students of the basic department) and advanced (for students of the vocational department). The primary level of debate is mainly one-on-one, with one challenger and one defender (see Fig. 2). Debates at the primary level typically focus on having the debaters jointly recall and memorize the knowledge learned in class. The advanced level of debate is primarily group debate, with multiple challengers and multiple defenders (see Fig. 3). Debates at the advanced level are more dialectic and aim to carry the participants to logical conclusions they may not have otherwise realized.

During our fieldwork, we noted there were observers and mentors during the debate. The observers sometimes stepped in when a debate was particularly intriguing while trying to help one of the debaters or refute extreme views. Mentors were responsible for ensuring that participants followed the rules. They also provided guidance, especially for new students still becoming familiar with debate-based learning. See "Debate 04" for the interaction among the different participants.

Unlike free-flowing conversation, Yin-Ming debate follows strict argumentation rules. In its most common one-on-one form, the challenger stands opposite the defender, who sits cross-legged on the ground. Generally, questions posed by the challenger are something they are familiar with, good at, or convinced of. The challenger's goal is to induce inconsistencies in the defender's previously-made argumentation. They question relentlessly, no matter how they personally view the issue or the defender. In contrast, the defender is committed to defending their claims. They must restore the consistency of the ideas they agree with by making further distinctions/explanations. In doing so, the defender usually gives one of three responses to each of the challenger's statements (Dreyfus, 2008): (1) I agree, (2) The answer is not established (when the answer is inconsistent with the subject), (3) No pervasion (when the statement does not apply to this class/category). The students in this study took turns playing these roles in daily debates. They sometimes acted as defenders, sometimes as challengers, and sometimes as observers (who were also important mood-setters of the event. They were quite a spectacle).

Moreover, the Yin-Ming debate is also unique in its drama-like manifestation. Students who played the challenger role showed hyperbolic movements and strongly-expressed emotions during the debate. When the challenger made a claim, it was often accompanied by shouting, clapping, and stomping. These gestures all pointed to the face of the seated defender as a symbol of challenge. The teachers we interviewed explained that these physical expressions contribute to the debate's positive and engaging quality. They also serve as symbolic reminders that the purpose of debate is to eliminate ignorance and reduce misunderstanding of reality (van Vugt et al., 2019). Any prolonged silence was considered a weakness during the debate. When the debater failed to respond, he would be teased by the opponent and observers ("shame" was often chanted). Overall, the debates were tense. This intensity constantly reminded debaters to think and respond quickly.

Today, debate serves as a guide for the curriculum and is used as a form of examination in Raja. As many Raja teachers believe and frequently emphasized, "Yin-Ming debate is a lifelong methodology of study." As a methodology of learning, everything can be debated. The school requires debate to be used in every subject to consolidate student learning. First, students receive new knowledge in class. Next, they memorize, contemplate the learning materials, and examine and deepen their memory and understanding through debate. The following example is a conversation between two ninth graders on the definition of water, which they had learned in

Fig. 2. The primary level of debate.

Fig. 3. The advanced level of debate.

science class. We mark it as "Debate 01."[9]

Challenger: Some people think that "wet and flowing" is the definition of water. Is that right?
Defender: Yes, I agree.
Challenger: Anything "wet and flowing" is water. Is that right?

(*continued on next page*)

[9] Though not directly borrowed from contemporary philosophy of science, this debate on the nature of water is reminiscent of modern thinking. See Chang (2012)'s *Is Water H_2O?*

(*continued*)

Defender: Yes, I agree. Is this not the consequence?
Challenger: Milk is water because it is wet and flowing. Do you agree?
Defender: The answer is not established (I disagree). Milk contains only part of water because milk also contains protein and other substances.
Challenger: Don't you think water is "wet and flowing?" Milk is sometimes "wet and flowing," isn't it?
Defender: The answer is not established. We can pour milk into a cup; then it won't flow (The defender disagrees that milk is water, and he believes that sometimes milk is not flowing).
Challenger: You just said there is water in milk, and you also agreed that anything "wet and flowing" is water. Now you say that milk is not necessarily flowing. Isn't it a contradiction? Your answer is inconsistent.
Defender: Um…
Challenger: What is the consequence?
Defender: (Silence)
Challenger: Answer the question! Come on! (accompanied by the shouting, clapping, and stamping of the challenger)
Defender: I agree with you. I was wrong. "Wet and flowing" is not the definition of water. (So far, the defender abandoned his original proposition)
Challenger: What is water, then?
Defender: I think "wet and flowing" is not the definition of water. If water is poured into a cup or frozen, then it is not "flowing." If the water evaporates into steam, it is not "flowing" either.
Challenger: You didn't answer my question. What is water? What is the consequence of that?
Defender: Um… Water is a liquid at normal temperature (So far, the defender has concluded a part of the definition of water).
Challenger: Is milk water? Is tea water? Is yogurt water?
Defender: They are not entirely water. They also contain other substances.
Challenger: What is water, then? What is the difference between water and these things (i.e., milk, tea, yogurt)?
Defender: They (i.e., milk, tea, and yogurt) all have a taste.
Challenger: Yes. Anything else?
Defender: (Silence)
Challenger: Do milk, tea, and yogurt all have colors?
Defender: Yes, they are.
Challenger: What color is water?
Defender: Water has no color.
Challenger: What is water, then?
Defender: Water is a colorless and tasteless liquid at normal temperature (The defender has concluded the definition of water).
Challenger: We also must consider the change in air pressure. In fact, water is a colorless and tasteless transparent liquid under normal temperature and pressure.

As mentioned previously, the Yin-Ming debate is not to refute nor overwhelm the counterpart by holding one's own unchanging/fixed views. Instead, as stressed by many Raja teachers, the purpose of debate is "to search for the truth and get rid of self-obsession." Debaters could revise their views throughout the debate until a consensus was reached. For instance, we recorded two eighth graders debating what they had learned in English class. They argued about the definition of family. The back-and-forth conversation gradually made the challenger abandon his original proposition, and the debaters reached a consensus. The highlight of this example was for the arguer to understand that family is a relational concept that invokes a sense of belonging. For details, see "Debate 02."

Debate was not only the consolidation of the content learned in class but also a hotbed for philosophical argumentation and dialectical reasoning for students at the advanced level (those in the vocational department). For example, topics like "Which is more important in poetry, rhetoric or idea?"[10] "Is education for girls the key to education equity?" "Is Buddhism superstitious?" were the most heated debate topics we had witnessed during our fieldwork. Teachers would regularly assign topics to students to cultivate their logical reasoning and critical thinking abilities. One day, Tsechi (a mentor) asked the students to debate whether Buddhism is superstitious. See "Debate 03" for a debate between two grade 11 students.

Tsechi provided this topic because he hoped that students would engage with religion critically and dialectically without confusing it with superstition. He emphasized that learning dialectics is the core of debate, not religion itself. The mentor never made a "final decision" or gave students the "correct answer" after each debate, and the conclusions drawn by each group of debaters were not necessarily the same.

Beyond the religious undertone of the content, here we treat debate as a pedagogy, as a methodology of learning and teaching. For many topics, science included, it is significant to secular educational practices. By applying this form of pedagogy to every subject in the school, Raja's educators hope to help students to convert knowledge from mere intellectual knowledge to embodied knowledge.

A good debate is unforeseeable and meaningful. It is carried out in an interactive, not a planned, way. This kind of indigenous oral practice can offer students substantial autonomy. Unlike the primary level, the advanced level of debate also had a collective element as the observers implicitly participated. In collaborative argumentation, debaters (sometimes also including teachers and observers) typically take turns to deploy irony, induction, reasoning, and co-construction as tactics to help all participants to reach logical conclusions, just as in the monastic tradition (Dreyfus, 2003). In this sense, debate in Raja can achieve Alexander's modern principle of collective, supportive, reciprocal, and deliberative results. However, due to teachers' limited participation, the debate's content and trajectory cannot be guaranteed. Students often could not chain their ideas into coherent understanding, and debates were lost in aimless talks. Therefore, this form of orality still falls short of the modern principle of cumulative and purposeful results.

[10] See "Debate 04" for this debate.

6. Conclusions

In today's China, one-way oral instruction is still the most common form of pedagogy (Wu, 2018, 2016). Like the "banking" concept proposed by Freire (1970), such instruction becomes an act of depositing, in which the students are the depositories, and the teacher is the depositor. In such classrooms, the argument is a sign of disruption and contention, which many educators aim to eliminate. However, the didactic teaching approach has disengaged many students, including those in rural/ethnic schools (Wu, 2012). In particular, minority students whose first language is not the national standard language or who lack the academic background to accumulate knowledge have suffered (Tong & Zhou, 2021).

This paper provides significant findings to the current discussion of disenchanted schooling. Instead of fully adopting a lecture-centric pedagogy, the dialogic teaching attracts learners toward culturally-relevant topics. Inspired by traditional monastic training, Raja's educators transformed the century-long oral practices into a culturally-appropriate form of pedagogy, infusing it into modern academic subjects.

The advantages of such dialogic teaching are evident in the examples presented in this study. The conversations motivated both teachers and students with authentic problems rather than depositing fixed answers. This pedagogy is evidently participatory, situational, and holistic. In Raja, oral practices occur in many classrooms, grade levels, and subjects. As the students participated in talks, we witnessed many great moments when the conversation encouraged students to think from different aspects, to read with understanding, and to listen to and learn from others to move beyond their initial prejudices. The interlocutors kept reflecting on the meaning and consequences of action during the conversations we observed. By listening and responding to others' ideas, the discussions brought everyone together. All members engaged in the discussion in a way that opened them to new possibilities. They related their experiences to the text and situations they may never really experience. By interpreting situations, they discovered relations between things, acquired analytic habits and skills, new ideas emerged, and their lives gained new meaning.[11]

The contemporary research community could have much to learn from the multitudes of such dialogic traditions. We have shown that dialogic teaching in a rural Tibetan school is broadly compatible with the principles of a modern framework. Whether in discussion or debate, schoolteachers create a collaborative learning environment for students. They can listen to each other, articulate their ideas freely, work together to resolve learning tasks, and help each other reach a reasoned consensus. This is also consistent with Alexander's first four principles. Our case highlights the centrality of dialogic teaching as a general pedagogy in the school system. We showed its versatility and elasticity. Dialogic teaching could be extended to a wide range of students, incorporated into many subjects, and used in many situations.

However, Raja's indigenous approach also limits the school practices to a small repertoire. There are fewer cumulative and purposeful actions in Raja's teaching activities. As Alexander (2020, p. 132) stated, cumulation is the most challenging principle to implement as it requires the teacher to have excellent professional skills, subject knowledge, and insight into the capacities and understanding of each student. Our findings indicate that many teachers in Raja are good at stimulating students' ideas but need to chain their ideas into coherent lines of thinking and understanding. Moreover, the principle of purposeful is also challenging to find in Raja. Influenced by Tibetan monastic culture, the educational goal in Raja is primarily processual, which aims to cultivate students' thinking abilities. Unlike many other Chinese schools we observed, teachers at Raja did not intentionally arrange each dialogue with a clear and specific educational goal. In many cases we witnessed, they focused more on the learning process rather than the content.[12]

The indigenous dialogic practice we studied at Raja embodies some of the same principles as its Anglophone version. However, this practice is narrower and only includes a few scholastic practices deemed essential in dialogic teaching. Dialogic teaching in Raja is rooted in Tibetan scholasticism, which has a set of indigenous and fixed repertoire. The indigenous form of dialogic practice also overlooks some critical aspects of the modern framework of dialogic teaching. Nevertheless, our analysis confirms that an indigenous pedagogy is compatible with modern dialogic philosophy. This study further suggests that the dialogic teaching is a general pedagogy rooted in distinctive human societies. As such, we propose two-way communication. Contemporary teacher education could broaden the discourse to include other non-Western practices of orality in school, while indigenous practitioners could have access to an informed theoretical base.

Data availability

The data that has been used is confidential.

[11] Such dialogic practice *has* benefited many students and built up a good reputation for the school. Raja's students are often in the top percentiles of the national debate competition. Their excellent performance provides them with more opportunities for further study. Interestingly, the college enrollment rate of Raja graduates will have reached 60 % by 2021, although they have only received six years of education.

[12] While the educational goal in Raja is primarily processual, it doesn't imply a neglect of the importance of content. There exists an inherent dynamic within the practices of educators in Raja, one that balances the process and the content. Raja encompasses both the characteristics of Tibetan monastic education (e.g., a focus on dialectical thinking, dialogic teaching, and the pursuit of wisdom beyond fixed knowledge) and certain elements of Chinese schools (e.g., an emphasis on recitation, the acquisition of fundamental knowledge, and the achievement of certain learning goals). We would describe it as a "middle ground" between traditional Tibetan philosophy and the contemporary Chinese vocational school model. As this middle ground, Raja's approach does indeed encapsulate the contradiction between process and content.

Appendix A. Supplementary data

Supplementary data to this article can be found online at https://doi.org/10.1016/j.lcsi.2023.100776.

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